PEAK LABOUR PLANNING — WAREHOUSE OPERATION

We needed agency starters fast. Here's the plan that didn't fall apart.

Most peak labour plans fail at onboarding — not at recruitment. Here's why, and what we did differently.

PEAK PERIOD — LABOUR GAP FORECASTING

The forecast said we needed 10 more people. Fast.

Workload was going up. The permanent team couldn't cover it. We had to bring in **a group of agency starters** within a short window.

The problem most operations hit at this point: they solve the recruitment problem and forget the **onboarding problem.** People arrive. They're put on the floor. The permanent team gets overloaded covering for them. And you end up paying for headcount that isn't contributing.

Four things you have to get right before day one.

1. **Contact multiple agencies — compare rates, availability, and operator profile**
   Cheapest isn't always lowest risk. We looked at reliability, sector experience, and typical notice period compliance.

2. **Compare agency cost against budget AND the risk of under-resourcing**
   Not just "can we afford this?" but "what does failing to cover this peak actually cost us?"

3. **Assign buddy operators before starters arrive**
   Named individuals. Briefed that their own output may dip during coaching. Given an escalation route if a starter isn't progressing.

4. **Define a structured ramp-up: controlled tasks → independence → full allocation**
   Not "induction then straight to the floor." A deliberate progression with readiness checkpoints.

Agency Onboarding — Starter Planning Dashboard

STARTERS REQUIRED	PLANNING WINDOW	AGENCIES COMPARED	BUDDY OPERATORS
Group intake	**Short window**	**Multiple**	**Named pairs**
peak period intake	forecast to floor-ready	rate, availability, profile	pre-assigned before arrival

STARTER RAMP-UP PROGRESSION — DAYS TO CONTRIBUTION LEVEL

Paying for headcount without a training plan is paying for noise.
The ramp-up structure is what converts arrival into contribution.

THE PRINCIPLE

Solve the onboarding problem, not just the recruitment one.

Getting bodies through the door is the easy part. Getting them contributing without overloading your permanent team — that's the real plan. Build the ramp-up before you call the agency.

Save this before your next peak period. ↓